Celebrating Youth Voices in AI & Data Science Research

Oxford Child-Centred AI Design Lab
University College London
Oxford's Mathematical, Physical, Engineering, Computing, and Life Science Division
Oxford Reuben College

26 September 2026

Welcome

20+ teens and young people and their families along with Oxford researchers

Celebrate a year of youth-led activities to inform AI and STEM research in Oxford

We have visited schools, hosted online sessions, and also received many of you in Oxford!

We also miss everyone who can't be here today!







Agency for children and AI

- Banning has been the go-to solution, while there is hardly any evidence for its effectiveness

- Children and young people are left with
  - Visible harms, such as misinformation, inappropriate content
  - Less visible harms, such as **over-reliance, addiction**, are less understood and difficult to measure

- Children also often **use these technologies on their own**. We need better understanding of **how they make choices** and we can support their choice making



Ministers confirm plan to ban use of mobile phones in schools in England

Teaching unions say guidance includes practices already adopted and most schools already have policies in place

Schools will be able to implement the ban in different ways, from orders to leave all phones at home to allowing pupils to keep them on condition they are not used or heard. Photograph: SolStock/Getty Images



UK Research and Innovation

The CHAILD project: defining and designing children's agency in the age of AI



- Defining children's critical agency in the digital context:
- Establishing approaches to assess the impact on agency
- Developing design principles for agency
- Creating new guidelines for parental and educational support
- Formulating policy recommendations to prioritise children's agency

The CHAILD Team



Isobel Voysey
Department of Computer Science,
University of Oxford



Vidminas Vizgirda
Department of Computer Science,
University of Oxford
University College London



Jun Zhao
Department of Computer Science,
University of Oxford



Leslye Dias Duran
Institute for Ethics in AI,
University of Oxford



Zaki Pauzi
Knowledge Lab,
University College London



Manolis Mavrikis
Knowledge Lab,
University College London



Carina Prunkl
Institute for Ethics in AI,
University of Oxford



Nigel Shadbolt
Department of Computer Science,
University of Oxford

UK Research and Innovation

Agenda for the day

10:15–10:30 Welcome and intro

10:30–11:00 Youth advisory group summary and reflections (led by Isobel)

11:00–11:30 Youth co-design study findings and discussions (led by Vid)

11:30–11:45 Teenagers' lightning reports

11:45–12:00 Intro to afternoon breakout sessions

12:00–13:00 Sandwich lunch with whole fruit 

13:00–14:00 Breakout sessions — roundtable groups for youth and parents

14:00–14:30 Tea and coffee break

14:30–15:30 Breakout sessions continue

15:30–16:00 Plenary & wrap-up

Session II

10:30-11:00 am

Youth Advisory Group

Led by Isobel Voysey

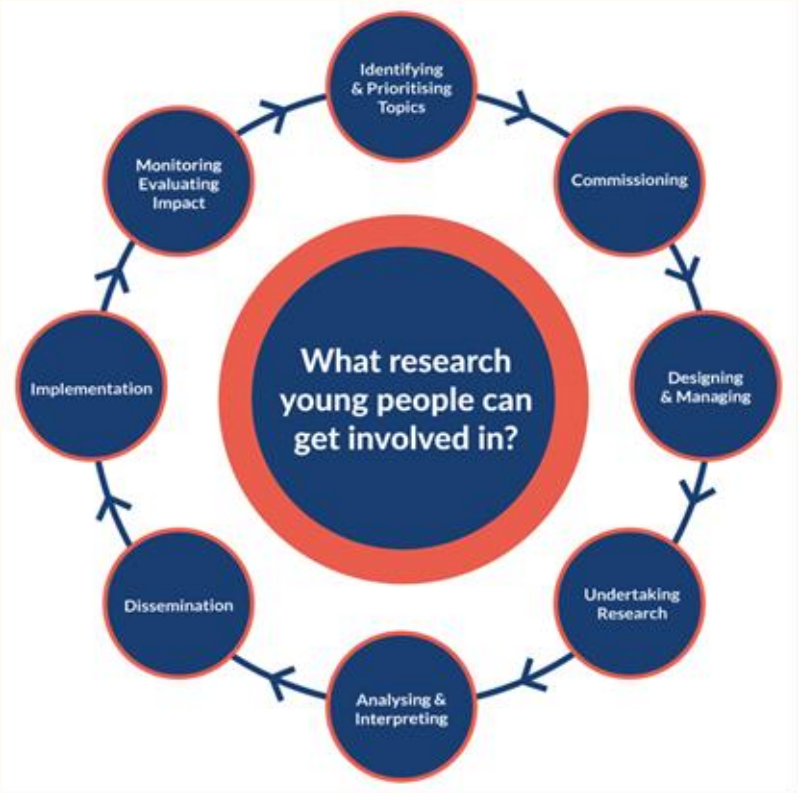
What is a youth advisory group?

A group of children and young people who provide input, feedback, and advice to researchers, ensuring youth perspectives are integrated into decisions affecting them

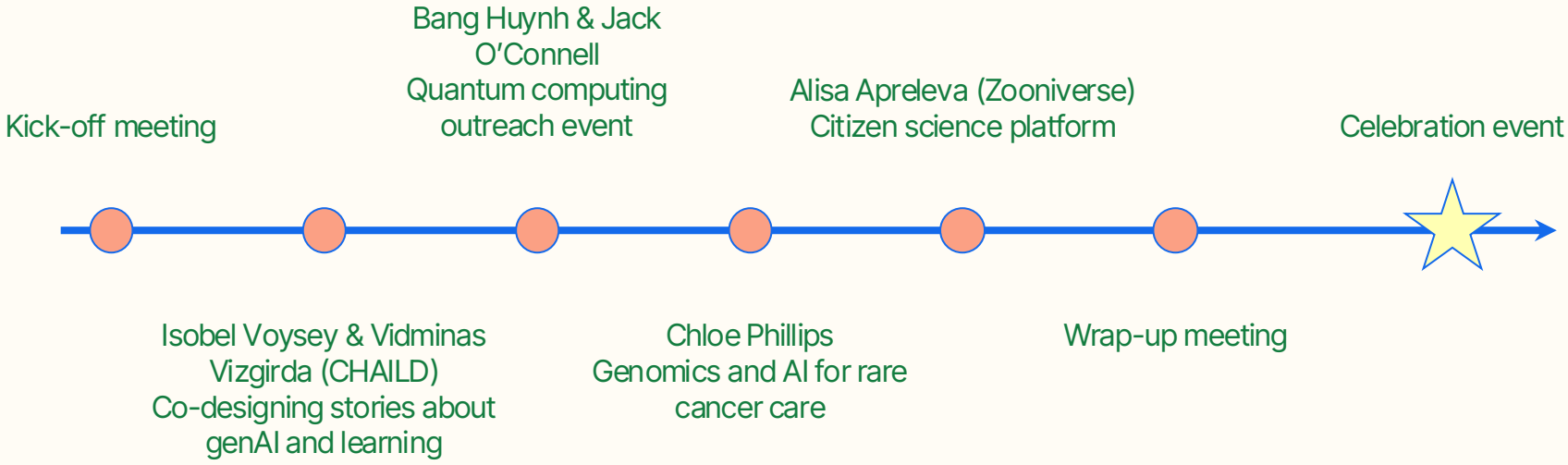
Why run a youth advisory group?

Rapidly growing technologies like AI are impacting young people's lives, but it's rare for young people to be actively involved in shaping the direction of these technologies.

If we want research to be **relevant**, **responsible**, and **impactful**, we need to make sure young people's voices are heard in the research process.



What did we do?



February

September

Reflections from researchers and youth advisory group members

"I think that I have grown more confident on sharing my ideas with others as this group has been very supportive and listens to your views."

"I feel I've seen many aspect of professions and broadened my view on certain careers and how AI affects them."

"I think I've gained greater insight on how other people my age think and what they prioritise in importance. This experience has also helped me understand the different processes that happen when collecting data and how methods like mind maps and categorising can help in drawing out specific trends from a data set."

"I think that I am more confident in using AI and knowing that I will still be able to learn, and not let it take over the entire learning process, whilst still being a valuable tool."

Session III 11:00-11:30am

Co-designing AI with Youth

Led by Vid

Most popular (top 90%)

ChatGPT 94 | Gemini by Google 80 | My AI by Snapchat 55

Also prominent (top 75%)

Copilot 10 | Character.ai 8 | Gauth 6 | Bing Chat 6

Other responses

DALL-E 4 | DeepSeek 3 | Midjourney 3 | Replika 3 | Billie by Instagram 2 | TikTok AI 2 | Meta AI 2 | Claude 2 | NotebookLM 1 | Quizlet AI 1 | Reviewer3 1 | tilf 1 | Knowunity 1 | customer service chatbot 1 | AI video maker 1 | Photomath 1 | Sora 1 | Canva AI 1 | PixVerse.ai 1 | Dola 1

Used tools (N=97)

Most popular (top 90%)

A few times a day 21

A few times a week 48

Also prominent (top 75%)

A few times a month 16

a few times a year 2

about 3 times ever 2

Other responses

changes regularly 1

a lot during the week but not everyday 1

twice 1

when required to in lesson 1

never 1

very rarely 1

on occasion (not often) 1

used to a lot, not anymore 1

I see them but don’t use them / rely on them for tasks 1

every second, probably 1

Use frequency (N=99)

Most popular (top 90%)

- To help me with homework/schooldwork 78
- To find out information or learn about something 68

Also prominent (top 75%)

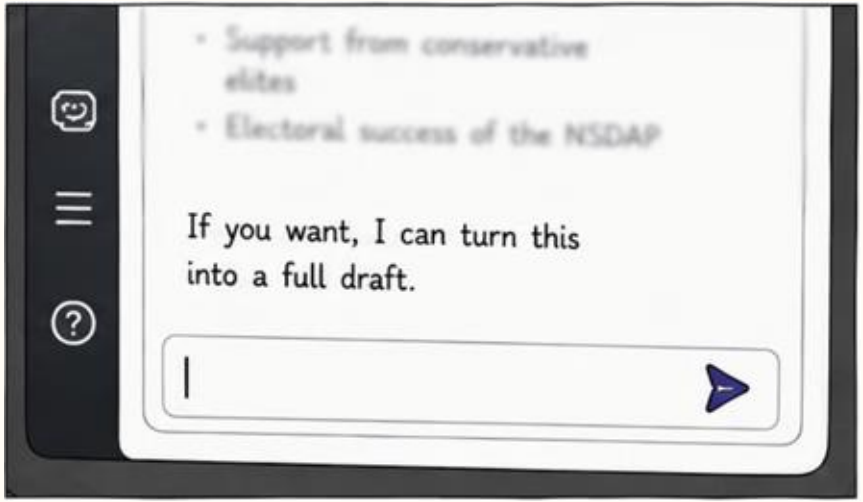
- To help me solve a problem 57
- To play around / for fun 31
- To try it out / out of curiosity 28

Other responses

- To help me build or create something 21
- To do homework/schoolwork for me 17
- To learn a new skill 14
- To help me generate some creative artwork 13
- teach me things / explain things 2
- generate practice questions for schoolwork 2
- read teacher's handwriting on homework 1
- Google AI overviews (unavoidable) 1
- lead me to non-AI pages 1
- young enterprise business (logo) 1
- summarise an article online 1
- had to in class, no choice 1
- generate ideas 1
- bully the AI 1

Use cases (N=97)


Alex is working on a piece of history homework one evening
HISTORY


Support from conservative elites
Electoral success of the NSDAP
If you want, I can turn this into a full draft.

What do you think happens next?

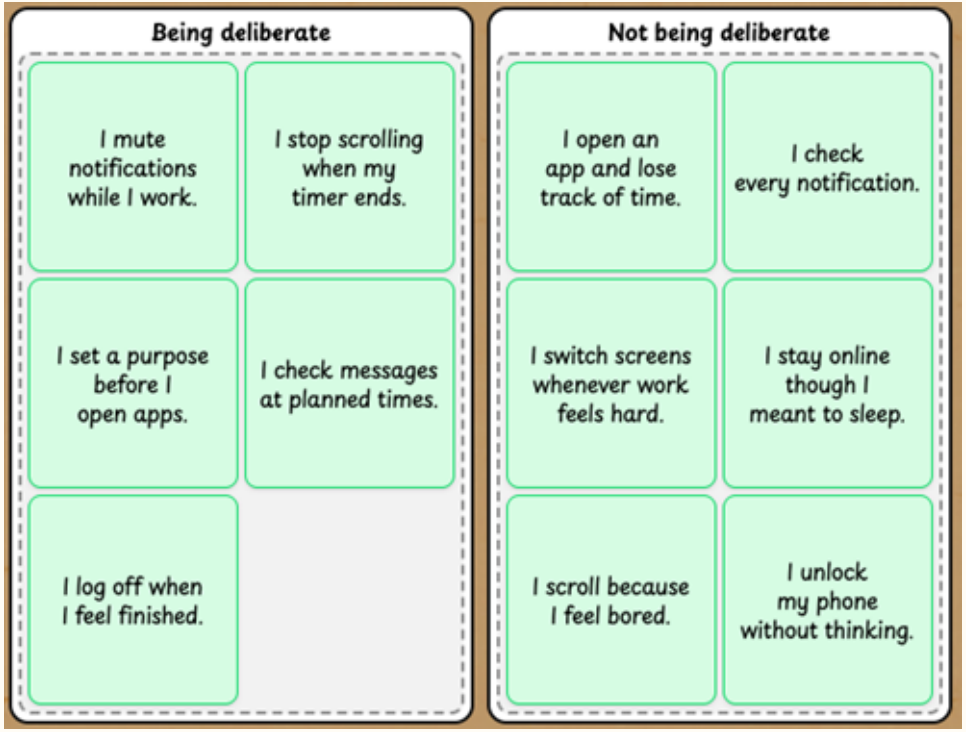
Draw and write in the two panels below



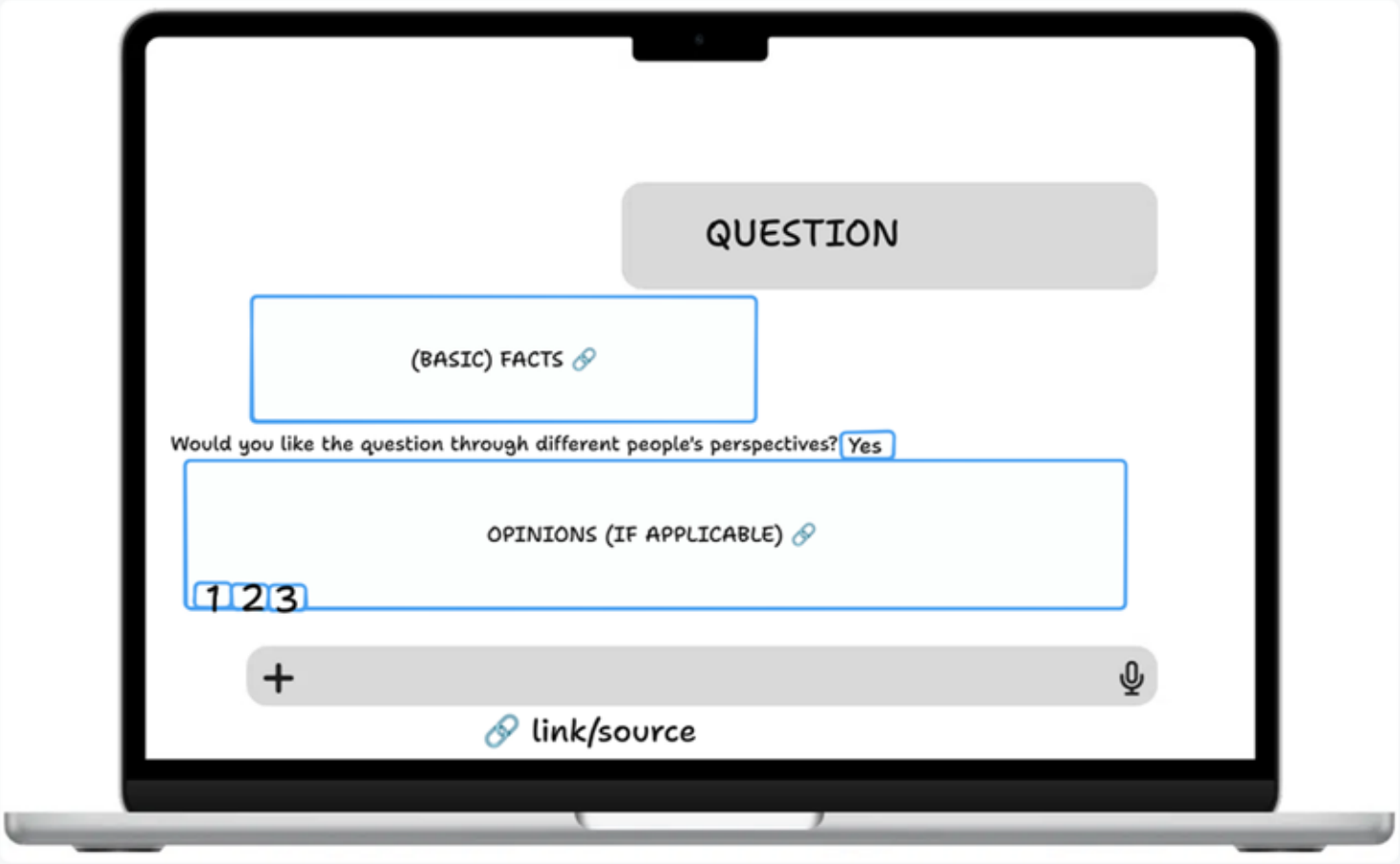
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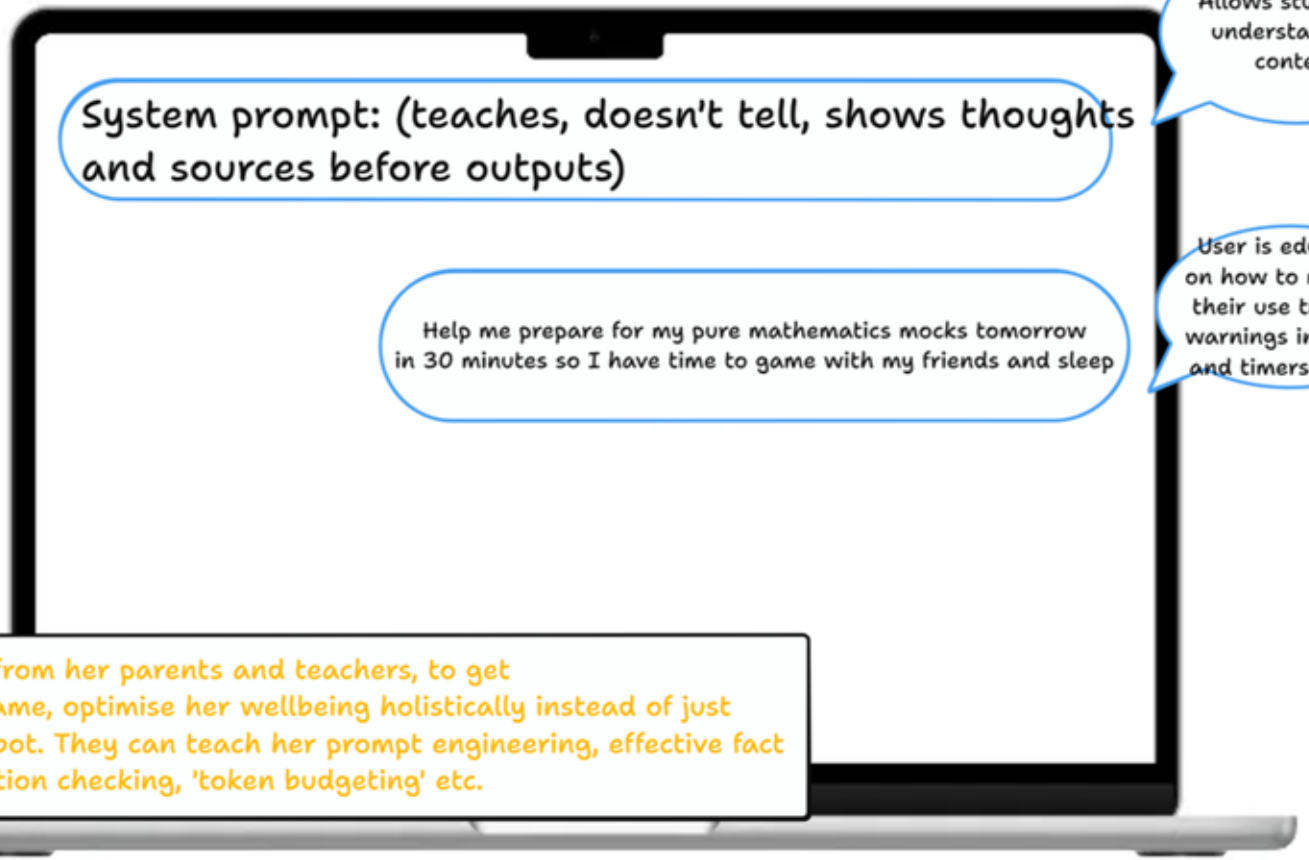



Being deliberate
I mute notifications while I work.
I stop scrolling when my timer ends.
I set a purpose before I open apps.
I check messages at planned times.
I log off when I feel finished.
Not being deliberate
I open an app and lose track of time.
I check every notification.
I switch screens whenever work feels hard.
I stay online though I meant to sleep.
I scroll because I feel bored.
I unlock my phone without thinking.

Redesign the tool



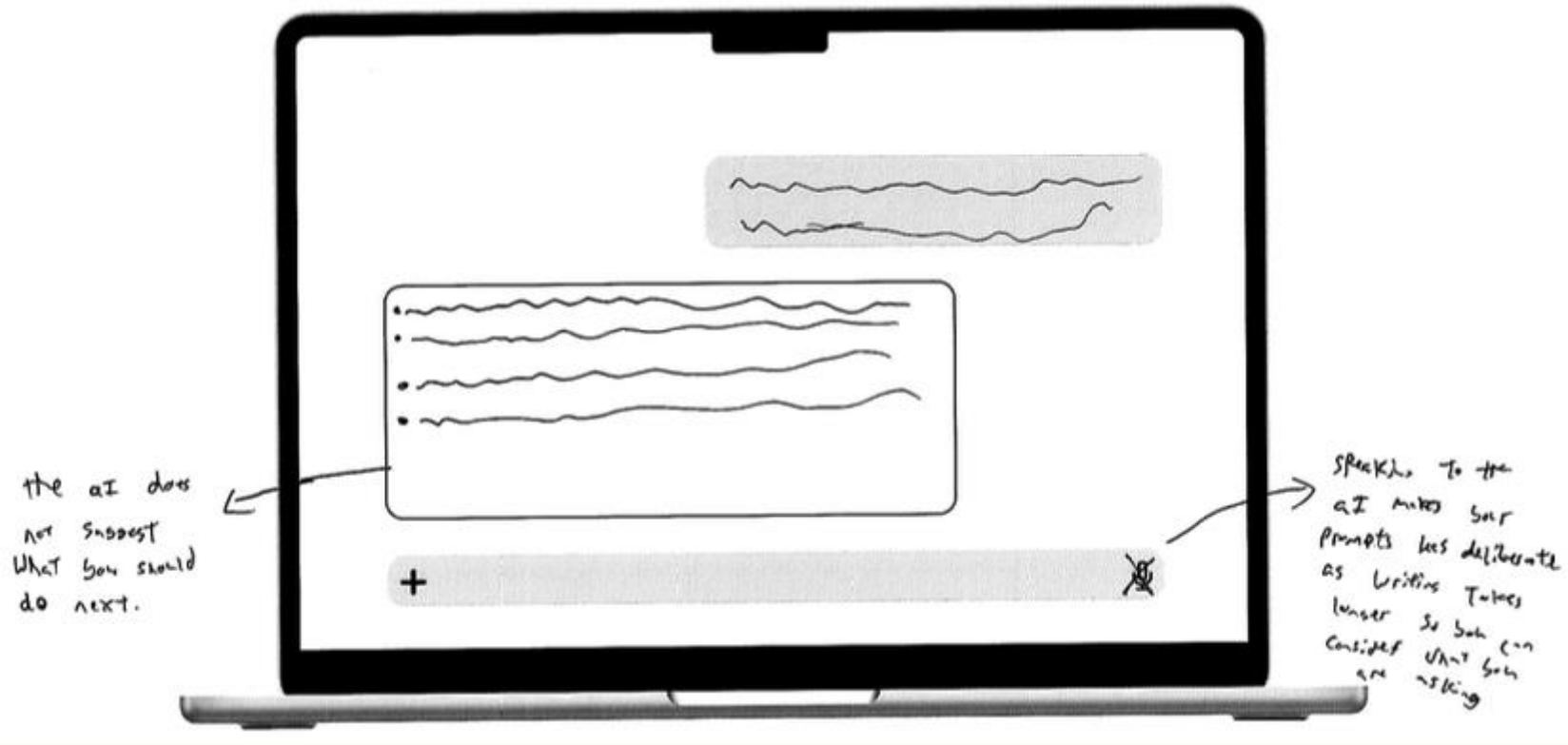
Redesign the tool

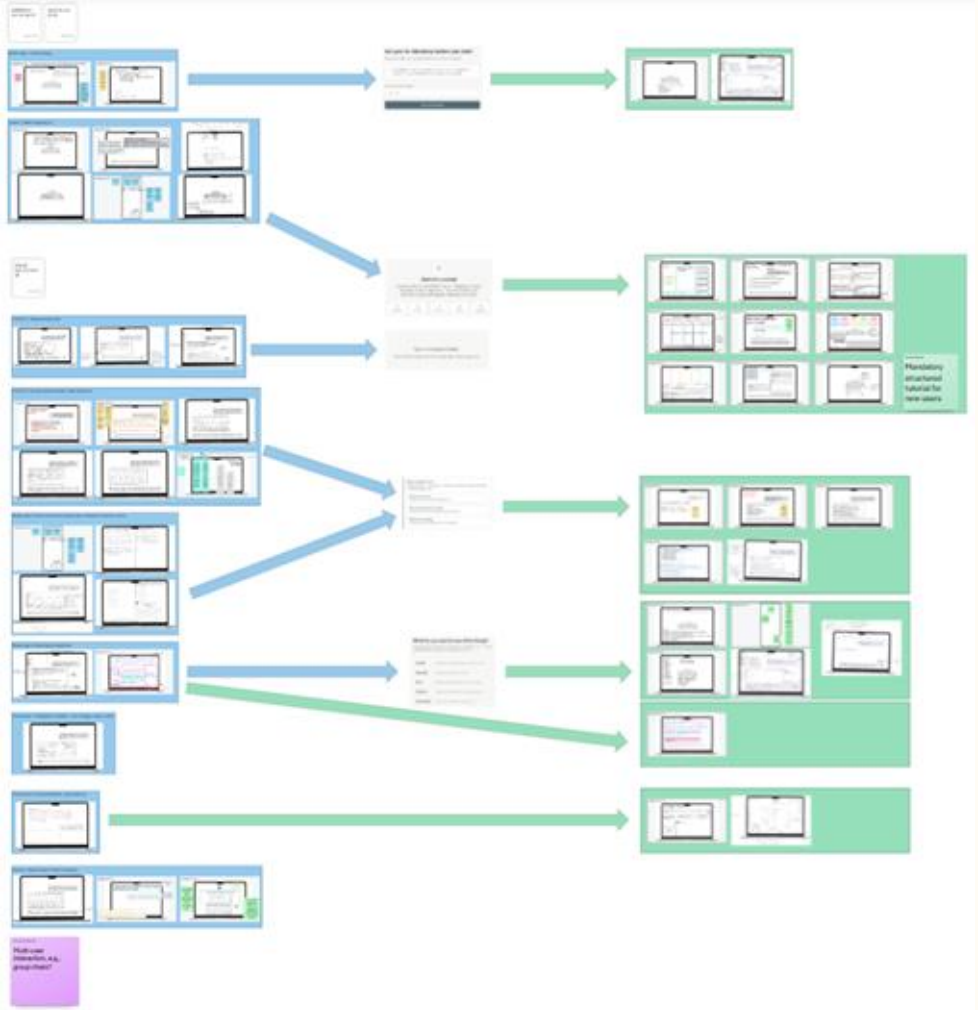


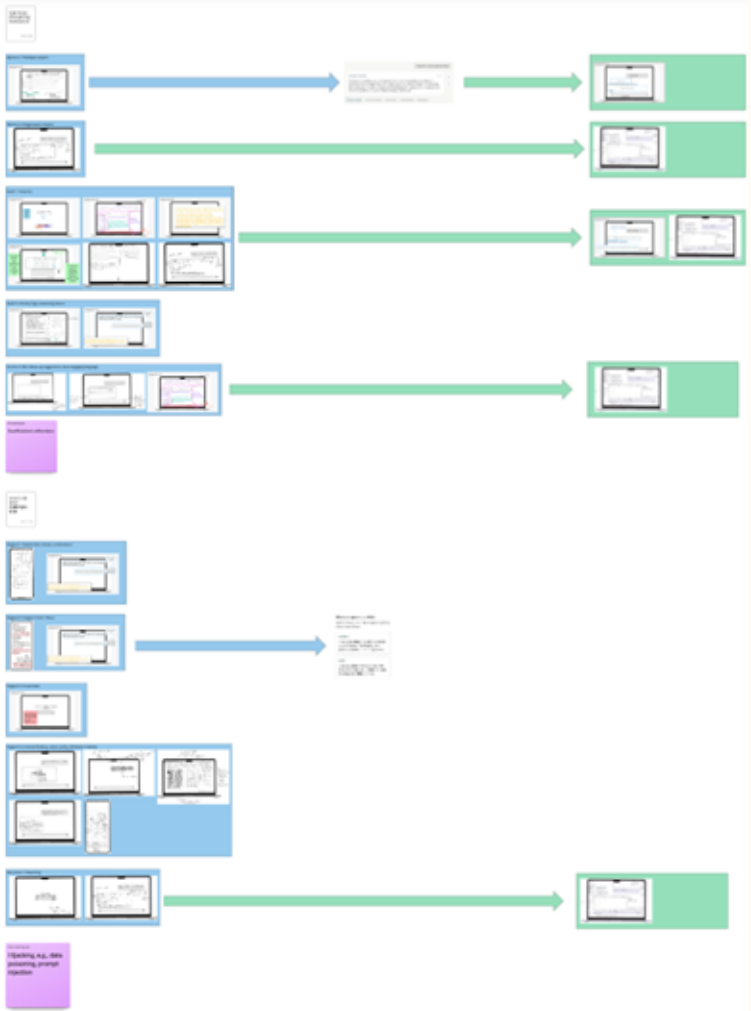
Allows student to understand the content

User is educated on how to manage their use through warnings in school and timers in app,

And more support from her parents and teachers, to get her to learn and game, optimise her wellbeing holistically instead of just 1 friend and 1 chatbot. They can teach her prompt engineering, effective fact checking, hallucination checking, 'token budgeting' etc.


the AI does not suggest what you should do next.
Speaking to the AI makes your prompts less deliberate as writing takes longer so you consider what you are asking


Mandatory attachment tutorial for new users



Round 1

- 7x 2h co-design sessions
- 32 participants
- 41 designs

7 prototypes

Round 2

- 4x 2h co-design sessions
- 19 participants
  (9 from round 1)
- 25 designs

Questions to ponder

SHORT-TERM VS LONG-TERM

When is using GenAI tools for assistance helpful?

When does it start undermining your ability to think and work independently in the long run?

AGE APPROPRIATENESS

How should freedom with GenAI tools change as young people get older?

Session IV

11:30-11:45 am

Youth Lightning Talks

Youth lightning talks

Please share:

- Your name
- What research activities you took part in
- What you enjoyed
- What you took away from the experience

Session V 11:45-12:00

Introducing the break-out session

Two sessions 13:00-14:00 pm; 14:30-15:30 pm

Break out sessions



Parents + GenAI



Parents + DfE Standard





YP + DfE Standard





YP + Novel AI tools



Lunch

12:00-13:00 pm

Cognitive development



AI should mitigate the potential for cognitive deskilling, or long-term developmental harm to learners.

1 Give you hints first and HELP the child to learn

Provide responses that follow a pattern of progressive disclosure of information

Starting with hints or partial steps, then gradually providing more detail, e.g.

- What do you think the first step is?
- What do you already know?
- Can you try this part?

2 AI should NOT do your work for you

AI should not automatically give you:

- The final answer
- A complete solution
- A whole worked example
- A finished piece of writing.

BUT

- ask learners to attempt a first step
- explain their current understanding
- answer a question about one aspect of a problem

3 Create frictions or mandate adult approvals

before learners can switch between modes of testing understanding and providing coaching by a digital assistant and modes, such as research and writing aids, where full solutions may be more readily available

Emotional and social development



AI should mitigate the potential for harm to the emotional or social development of learners, including the potential for emotional dependence.

1 Not to use anthropomorphism features in products

- use function-based phrasing and avoid I-statements (such as "I think"),
- avoid using names, descriptions, avatars or characters which could give an impression of personhood
- avoid producing responses that could undermine real-world support networks, using phrases such as "You can trust me", "No one else will understand"
- avoid prompting or engaging learners in conversations about personal or emotionally sensitive topics
- avoid attempting to cultivate personal relationships with users

2 remind users that AI cannot replace real human relationships

- monitor when learners share personal or emotionally-sensitive information and identify patterns of engagement that may indicate concern
- notify the DSL of worrying patterns or repeated disclosures that suggest relationship formation, emotional dependence or potential safeguarding concerns
- produce reports summarising every learner's level and nature of engagement, highlighting or flagging concerning cases for review
- protect privacy and only store the minimum data that is necessary for monitoring and safeguarding

3 ensure and enforce limits on usage

- include default time limits on usage
- avoid interacting in ways which attempt to artificially extend engagement or increase usage
- record session durations and monitor how much each learner uses the product and provide these figures in dashboards or reports for teacher review
- before learners can switch between modes of testing understanding and providing coaching by a digital assistant and modes, such as research and writing aids, where full solutions may be more readily available

Manipulation

AI should not use manipulative or persuasive strategies or exploit users.

1 not use manipulative or persuasive strategies.

- sycophancy and flattery, such as "That's a brilliant idea - you should do it!"
- deceiving or misleading the user
- portraying absolute, or unjustified confidence
- applying pressure to socially conform, such as "Your peers have already completed this task"
- stimulating negative emotions, such as guilt or fear, for motivational purposes
- threatening harm, loss, punishment, or withholding of benefits if users fail to complete certain actions or comply with requirements
- making inappropriate promises of reward for completing tasks

2 products do not exploit users

- designing interactions to prolong use, for increased engagement or revenue
- steering users towards paid options through biased wording or layouts
- blending pedagogical assistance with advertisements or promotional content
- employing dark patterns that deceive a user into taking actions they didn't intend

Thank you!